

Preterm See [Premature](#).

Primigravida A woman who is in her first pregnancy.

Progesterone A hormone produced by the corpus luteum and placenta.

Prostaglandins Natural substances that stimulate the onset of contractions; can be used during an induction of labor.

Rh immunoglobulin (RhIg) An injection of antibodies given to women who have a Rhesus negative blood group if they may have been exposed to Rhesus positive fetal blood cells.

Rhesus factor A distinguishing characteristic of the red blood cells. All human beings have either Rhesus positive or Rhesus negative blood. If the mother is Rhesus negative and the fetus Rhesus positive, rhesus disease may occur, but can be prevented by an injection of Rh immunoglobulin (RhIg).

Rooting The baby's instinctive searching for the breast.

Stillbirth The delivery of a dead baby after the 20th week of pregnancy.

Surfactant A creamy fluid that reduces the surface tension of the lungs so that they do not stick together when deflated. Premature babies may have breathing difficulties if surfactant has not developed sufficiently.

TENS See [Transcutaneous electronic nerve stimulation](#).

Transcutaneous electronic nerve stimulation A method of pain relief that uses electrical impulses to block pain messages to the brain.

Transducer An instrument that translates echoes of high-frequency sound waves, bounced off the developing fetus in the uterus, to create an image on a monitor.

Transition A phase between the first and second stages of labor when the cervix is dilating to between 7 and 10 cm.

Trial of labor A situation in which, although a cesarean section may be necessary, the mother labors in order to see if a vaginal delivery is possible.

Twins The simultaneous development of two babies in the uterus, either after two eggs are fertilized independently by two sperm—dizygotic or fraternal twins—or, more rarely, after one fertilized egg divides to produce monozygotic or identical twins.

Ultrasound scan A way of building up a picture of an object by bouncing high-frequency soundwaves off it. Ultrasound scans are used during pregnancy to show the development of the fetus in the uterus. See also [Transducer](#).

Vernix A creamy substance that often covers the fetus in the uterus.

VBAC (Vaginal Birth After Cesarean) A situation in which a woman delivers vaginally after having a previous Cesarean (in the past, if a woman had had a Cesarean, any subsequent birth would be a cesarean).